recognition and local performance becomes even more pronounced with opposition and non-BJP stalwarts who have dominated Indian political discourse for decades. Mamata Banerjee of West Bengal, N. Chandrababu Naidu of Andhra Pradesh, Nitish Kumar of Bihar and M.K. Stalin of Tamil Nadu feature prominently in the national popularity rankings, benefiting from their high media visibility and long political careers. Yet when voters in their own states are asked to evaluate their performance, only Naidu manages a satisfaction rating approaching 40 per cent, placing him among the top five, while Mamata languishes at just 30.1 per cent, a precipitous fall from 46 per cent six months earlier. Again, this could be a worrying signal ahead of her electoral test next year.

BJP's Edge

The BJP's dominance in the performance metrics presents a compelling narrative about its governance model and reception among voters. Six of the top 10 best-performing CMs helm BJP-governed states, a remarkable achievement that underscores the party's ability to translate electoral victories into, at least, perceived administrative competence. The roster includes not just ideological hardliners like Yogi and Himanta, but also their lower-profile counterparts like Vishnu Deo Sai of Chhattisgarh and Mohan Yadav of Madhya Pradesh, suggesting that the BJP's governance template, whether focused on Hindu nationalism, development or welfare schemes, has found a receptive audience. By contrast, no Congress CM finds a place in this top bracket, exposing the party's state-level organisational weakness and its inability to convert incumbency into credibility. It's a damning indictment of India's principal Opposition party's governance record.

Among the Opposition faces, Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren stands out as an unexpected success story. After a turbulent spell out of office, he has returned with a striking turnaround, climbing from 31 per cent satisfaction six months ago to nearly 42 per cent now, enough to place him third in the overall ratings. The surge suggests Soren's second innings may prove steadier than anticipated and offers the Opposition a rare glimmer of encouragement at a time when most of its state leaders struggle to be seen as credible performers. His rise also highlights a broader truth: voters can set aside past controversies when leaders manage to deliver tangible governance.

The elevation of previously struggling leaders offers another compelling narrative. Bhagwant Singh Mann of Punjab, whose approval rating has surged from a dismal 17 per cent to nearly 30 per cent, demonstrates that CMs can recover from early missteps if they adjust their governance approach.

Small but Rising

The poll also highlights promising trends from India's smaller states, where leaders often govern beyond the glare of national attention. In Sikkim, CM Prem Singh Tamang continues to command majority approval, with around 53 per cent of respondents in his state expressing satisfaction with his performance. This places him at the very top nationwide for the second consecutive round.

Taken together, the findings point to a central paradox in Indian politics today. The most visible CMs—combative, ideological and relentless in their projection—are not always the ones securing satisfaction at home. Yogi remains the rare exception, managing to dominate the national stage while holding steady in his own state. Meanwhile, Himanta and Mamata illustrate the hazards of overexposure and inflated expectations, particularly in the run-up to elections. The Congress's absence from the list of top performers underscores its deepening state-level crisis, while the BJP's prominence reflects leaders increasingly moulded in the party's ideological and electoral image.

The broader lesson for CMs is clear: ideological clarity and political aggression may deliver visibility, but lasting success still depends on the harder test of sustained governance. ■

BEST PERFORMING CMs (HOME STATE/ SMALL*)

Respondents in every state were asked to rate their own CM



RAJWANT RAWAT

1 PREM SINGH TAMANG
Sikkim
53.9 [62]



2 PEMA KHANDU
Arunachal Pradesh
41.6 [42]



3 DR MANIK SAHA
Tripura
40.4 [39]



4 CONRAD SANGMA
Meghalaya
38.6 [38]



5 LALDUHOMA
Mizoram
38.4 [38]

Respondents were asked to evaluate the performance of their own CM. For instance, 53.9% respondents of the total of 300 from Sikkim said they were satisfied with Prem Singh Tamang while 41.6% of the 300 respondents from Arunachal Pradesh expressed satisfaction at Pema Khandu's performance

** States with less than 10 Lok Sabha seats*

All figures in %; rest, others; Aug. '25 figures in bold red, Feb. '25 in [ ]